2010). But, Russia was sidelined throughout the entire period of the last decade of the twentieth century. The National Security Concept of the Russian Federation (2000) declared:

> Several states are stepping up efforts to weaken Russia politically, economically, militarily, and in other ways. Attempts to ignore Russia's interests when resolving significant issues in international relations, including conflict situations, can undermine global security and stability and inhibit the positive changes occurring in international relations.

After the Yugoslavian breakup and conflict,[27] Russian policymakers changed their policy structure significantly. Russia and China settled their long-standing border issue of 4300 km (De Haas 2010). Further, a more pragmatic and assertive foreign policy emerged since Putin's reign. Putin emphasized southern world countries like China, India, and Iran through political, economic, and military tools, especially ‘pariah’ states like North Korea and Cuba (ibid.). The Russian Constitution clearly stated that it was ‘reviving the sovereign statehood of Russian federation and asserting the firmness of its democratic basis of world politics’ (Russian Federation Constitution 1993).

In August 2008, when Russian forces invaded and occupied large parts of Georgia, Russia gave the impression to the international community that it was back as a powerful country (De Haas 2010). The foreign policy of Medvedev also underscored that their primary focus would be the Troika states, i.e., India and China. Russia became more powerful in the later part of Putin's regime in the Kremlin. At the same time, the Arab crisis, the predominantly Syrian crisis,[28] Iran's nuclear issues, and the Ukraine crisis[29] plunged Russian and Western relations to the nadir level (Akulov 2013a).

Likewise, the rise of China as a great power with huge ambitions had started since World War II, after the collapse of Germany and Russia (Robinson and Shambaugh 1994). But throughout the history of the Cold War period, China was in search of its destiny with several internal and external problems and remained a mere supporter of the USSR till the early 1960s. However, China's foreign policy was changed after the USSR demolition in 1991. In 1991, Qian Qichen stated that Chinese foreign policy would be guided by five principles: non-aligned movement, mutual respect